

Anyone who stops learning is old, whether at twenty or eighty.

—Henry Ford

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When someone starts at the bottom, and reaches the top, he is the one most likely to be the leader everyone else wants to become.

A brief look at his CV reveals how he has risen from the bottom, worked with the likes of TI, National Semi, STATs ChipPAC, DTS, founded Tessolve, and now is the CEO of Tata Electronics' OSAT unit. A closer look reveals how he has accepted different roles (from sales to engineering to business development) with these different companies. While Raja's first job was as a test engineer, he later learned chip design, SPICE modelling and a lot of other things around semiconductors. Raja's favourite subject at IIT used to be solid-state physics, and solid-state physics and semiconductors go together!

Raja has also been on the front side of running a semiconductor factory for National Semiconductor in Malaysia. Although he had moved to the USA to work with National Semiconductor, the company asked him to run the engineering side of the Malaysia factory as part of their strategic move. He directly managed teams consisting of 300 engineers and was the man behind a lot of new product introductions for National Semi. He stayed in Malaysia for about three years before moving back to the States. Once in the States, he decided to move to the mecca of the startup world—The Bay Area.

A question!

There comes a point in almost everyone's life where they want to start something of their own. Most commonly referred to as the startup route, not all can muster courage to walk this road. But when you are in the Bay Area of the States and are reading about new startups coming out in the area every day, the air around becomes more than what is required to fuel the bold step. Once you are in the Bay Area, you start talking more about starting companies than anything else. I took the step in 2004 and started my own company," recalls Raja.

Wait, the journey to start a semiconductor company was just not fuelled by the air of the Bay Area. Raja was not happy with the quality of people he was working with before starting Tessolve. Every evening he

would return home frustrated and tell his wife about the lack of eagerness his co-employees had in the companies he was associated with in the Bay Area. He would complain that people around him had no idea what they were doing. On one fine evening Raja, as usual, returned from work, and started complaining again. To which his wife replied, "If you are so smart why don't you start your company?"

This was the moment, and probably the question that made Raja realise that he was not happy being an employee anymore. However, it was also the time when his kids were on the brink of completing their education. Leaving a job and starting something of your own at that moment would have been a risk, but Raja calculated the ups and down and took the decision!

Before proceeding further, it is important to note here that Raja's wife, Vetriselvi, comes from a political family. Her father has served as an industry and law minister in the Tamil Nadu cabinet. He was the youngest minister in the Tamil Nadu cabinet in 1967 under the first DMK government. Raja admits that his father-in-law taught him a lot about statesmanship, and at the same time leading a simple life. Raja's wife runs a non-profit Tamil School in the Bay Area, which has over 20,000 volunteers.

Back to startups, Raja asked his wife that he was keen to do it but what if something went wrong, and they lost everything they had saved? His wife's reply was, "As long as you do not sell my jewellery, we will be fine! Sell the house or whatever else you want but do not sell my jewellery." Vetriselvi translated to English means victory!

Most of the community members from Manickam's community are either into agriculture or are into small-time business. It was Vetriselvi's father, the minister, who reached out to Raja's parents in the same community with a proposal for marriage. It was an arranged marriage, and the most romantic thing that Raja says he has done for his wife is taking her along to every meet he attends. Raja was employed with TI when the couple got married. Raja and Vetriselvi have always encouraged each other to